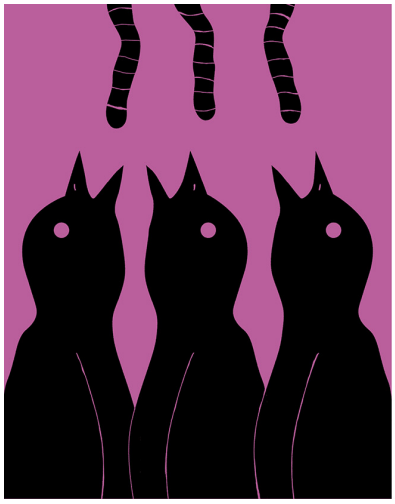


# BIRDS LAY THE NUMBER OF EGGS THAT PRODUCE THE OPTIMUM NUMBER OF OFFSPRING

## CLUTCH CONTROL

### IN CONTEXT

KEY FIGURE

**David Lack** (1910–73)

BEFORE

**1930** British geneticist Ronald Fisher combines Gregor Mendel's work on genetics with Charles Darwin's theory of natural selection, and argues that the effort spent on reproduction must be worth the cost.

AFTER

**1948** David Lack extends his theory of optimal clutch size in birds to include litter size in mammals.

**1954** Lack develops his food limitation hypothesis further in *The Natural Regulation of Animal Numbers*, to encompass birds, mammals, and some insect species.

**1982** Tore Slagsvold proposes the nest predation hypothesis, which states that clutch size is related to the likelihood of the nest being attacked.

Why do some birds lay more eggs than others? For example, Blue Tits lay nine eggs, Northern Flickers six, and Robins four. In the 1940s, British ornithologist and evolutionary ecologist David Lack proposed an explanation that rapidly gained support. He argued that the clutch size